

Week-6 Essay (Chapter 10 of WMD and Chapter 7,8 of Everybody Lies)

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Introduction

In Chapter 10, *The Targeted Citizen: Civic Life*, Cathy O'Neil explores how predictive algorithms and big data can manipulate political engagement, suppress voter participation, and exacerbate societal inequalities. These systems target specific voter groups with tailored misinformation or ignore them completely, posing a serious threat to democracy. Meanwhile, in Chapters 7 and 8 of *Everybody Lies*, the author highlights the limitations and ethical concerns surrounding big data. Chapter 7 warns that large datasets don't always lead to better insights and can oversimplify complex issues, while Chapter 8 emphasizes the dangers of data misuse by corporations and governments, calling for ethical guidelines to ensure responsible use. Together, these chapters show both the promise and the risks of big data, urging caution and responsibility in how it's used.

Literature Review

The chapter 10 discusses how political campaigns use big data and microtargeting to send personalized messages to voters based on their data profiles, often with the help of algorithms that identify persuadable voters. While this can engage voters, it also leads to disinformation and the suppression of opposing views. A key example is the 2016 U.S. presidential election, where targeted social media ads influenced voter behavior by appealing to people's frustrations, ultimately impacting the election outcome. Similarly, in other countries, these tactics deepen social divisions and manipulate voters for political gain, while algorithms may also exclude certain groups, like minorities or low-income individuals, from outreach campaigns, further silencing marginalized voices.

In chapters 7 and 8 discuss the limitations and ethical concerns of big data, drawing from broader debates in data science, measurement theory, and ethics. Stephens-Davidowitz critiques the overconfidence in big data, highlighting issues like the "curse of dimensionality," where complex datasets can lead to false conclusions, as seen in medical diagnostic models. He also points out the overemphasis on measurable metrics, where platforms like Google and Facebook focus on engagement without considering broader impacts on mental health or societal well-being. Additionally, big data often ignores "dark matter," such as the chemistry in dating apps that algorithms fail to capture. He further warns about the limits of predictions, citing election forecasting errors like underestimating Trump's support in 2016. These concerns are also reflected in ethical issues, including corporate misuse of personal data and the dangers of authoritarian surveillance, emphasizing the need for responsible data use and strong ethical oversight.

Analysis of the Issue

Cathy O'Neil critiques the biases and dangers of algorithmic decision-making in civic contexts, highlighting several key issues. First, algorithms contribute to disenfranchisement by prioritizing cost-effective engagement and ignoring voters seen as unlikely to participate, silencing their voices in democracy. Second, microtargeting creates echo chambers, reinforcing existing beliefs and deepening societal divides by limiting exposure to diverse viewpoints. Additionally, campaigns manipulate trust by spreading misinformation to targeted groups, eroding public confidence in democratic systems and causing long-term harm to civic unity. Finally, the lack of accountability in how political campaigns and tech companies run these algorithms allows unethical practices to continue without oversight.

In Chapter 7, Stephens-Davidowitz critiques the idea that big data can solve everything, pointing out key limitations. He discusses the "curse of dimensionality," where too many variables can lead to false patterns, as seen in complex medical models. He also highlights how big data focuses too much on measurable metrics, like social media engagement, while ignoring important factors like mental health or emotional impact. Additionally, big data misses critical "dark matter," such as the chemistry in relationships that apps fail to capture. Finally, he warns that even with vast data, predictions can still be wrong, citing the 2016 election as an example.

Conclusion and Limitations

In Chapters 7, 8, and 10, O'Neil highlights how big data and algorithms are reshaping politics by making campaigns more efficient but also more prone to biases that can suppress votes and deepen divides. She stresses the need for transparency and regulation to protect democracy. While big data offers valuable insights, its limitations and potential for misuse such as the "curse of dimensionality" and privacy concerns can not be ignored. From my point of view, it is crucial to use these tools in a way that enhances campaigns without compromising fairness. Without proper oversight, these tools could continue to harm democracy and unfairly influence elections. I believe the key is using big data responsibly balancing innovation with respect for human values so it can benefit society without undermining privacy or fairness.

References

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- O'Neil, C. (2016). In *Weapons of math destruction: how big data increases inequality and threatens democracy*. Crown Publishers.